

# WHIP General Board Meeting Minutes — May 2026

## Meeting Details

**Date:** May 2026

**Location:** Walnut Hills High School Room 2210 and Google Meet

**Time:** Meeting called to order around 7:15 PM due to Google Meet technical difficulties

## Attendance

*Present:* Patricia Duque Campos, Aubrey Backscheider, Tracy Cohen, Melissa, Adair, Mr. Nims, Mr. Cantor, Mr. Peebles, and others in person/online

## 1. Call to Order

- Meeting start was delayed because the original Google Meet link was created by Rick, who was not present.
- Some participants were unable to enter the meeting without host approval.
- A new Google Meet link was briefly created as a backup.
- Patricia monitored the Google Meet while the in-person meeting proceeded.
- Meeting called to order after technical difficulties were resolved.

## 2. Minutes

- April meeting minutes were distributed by Patricia.
- Motion made to approve April minutes.
- Aubrey seconded.
- **Result:** Approved

### 3. Department News

#### Choir

- **Mozart Requiem performance:**

- Choir students performed Mozart's *Requiem* with the Hyde Park Community United Methodist Church choir, professional orchestra, and soloists.
- Performance went very well.
- Students performed alongside singers ranging in age from 16 to 80.
- The collaboration gave students a strong experience with a major choral work.

- **Music in the Parks:**

- Junior Choir and Vocal Ensemble competed at Music in the Parks.
- Both groups earned first place in their categories.
- Both groups also earned first place overall among vocal ensembles.
- Combined score was approximately 97.5 out of 100.
- Junior Choir received the highest score of any performing ensemble at the competition, with a 98 out of 100.

- **Upcoming concerts:**

- Junior high and senior high choir concerts are scheduled for the following Monday and Tuesday.
- Concerts will include collaboration with other departments and instrumental support.

#### Orchestra

- Preparing for upcoming orchestra concerts and graduation music.
- Graduation rehearsal logistics discussed:
  - Students will rehearse during the school day.

- Students may be released after rehearsal rather than returning to school.
- Only a small number of students indicated they would need transportation back to school.
- Discussion held about possible conflicts between graduation commitments and final exam review.
  - Concerns were raised that students may miss review time or have less time to study.
  - Directors noted that students with academic conflicts may be able to make individual decisions.
- Broader concerns discussed about the school exam schedule, especially finals after winter break.
  - Several attendees expressed concern that Walnut students may not be able to truly rest over break if finals are afterward.
  - It was noted that changing the schedule would significantly affect the music calendar.

## Band

- **New student audition day:**
  - Around 40 students auditioned for band.
  - Several additional students reached out after the audition day.
  - Tri-M students helped and did a great job.
  - The event ran smoothly.
- **Jazz Band:**
  - Final jazz concert was held and went very well.
  - WHIP support was acknowledged during the concert.
  - Jazz awards:
    - Woody Herman Award: Lane Aiello
    - Louis Armstrong Award: J.J. Mangan

- **Upcoming band events:**

- Junior high band concert: Wednesday
- Senior high band concert: Thursday
- Senior high concert will include a world premiere and feature student soloist Tabasta Gajar.
- Steel band concert: Friday at 7:00 PM in the Triangle Courtyard, weather permitting.

- **Marching Band:**

- Marching band show is almost fully written.
- Show reveal planned for Friday.

- **Breakthrough T1D event:**

- A small marching band group will perform at a Breakthrough T1D event this weekend.
- The organization will make a payment to the marching band.
- Bengals player Orlando Brown Jr. and other Bengals representatives are expected to attend.

- **Steel Band 25th Anniversary:**

- Next year will be the 25th anniversary of the steel band.
- Special concert planned for Saturday, March 6, 2027.
- Plans may include guest artists, an alumni band, and a commissioned piece.
- WHIP discussed possible advance publicity and charging admission for the special guest-artist concert.

## **Strings**

- 38 string players auditioned, the largest number reported.
- Many students were younger, including a large number of sixth graders, which should help build the program.

- A few students auditioned into higher-level groups.
- Music Award recipient:
  - Shalin King, senior cellist
  - Received a full ride to Ohio State for music performance and a second major, possibly political science.

## 4. Finances

### Point-of-Sale / Payment System

- WHIP has been working on a point-of-sale system so more people can take card payments and donations.
- PayPal provided nonprofit terminals at no cost.
- Leslie has the terminals and will try them at larger concerts.
- Terminals may allow card payments at:
  - Concert donation tables
  - Magnet sales
  - Spaghetti Dinner
  - Concessions
  - Other events
- No contract is required.
- Standard PayPal transaction fees apply.
- Adair was thanked for previously loaning her Clover device.

### Budget / Financial Report

- Directors and Leslie have been working through several budget drafts.
- Executive board will meet with Rick to review and approve the budget, as required by bylaws.
- Current financial position:

- Just under \$102,000 total in the bank
- Approximately \$86,000 unrestricted
- Remaining funds are restricted
- Net income:
  - Approximately negative \$14,000
- Expected upcoming income:
  - Walnut Quest/Walnut Fest check, expected around \$8,000
  - Marching band deposits and payment 2 before the end of the fiscal year
  - Concert donations from upcoming concerts
- Recent expenses were expected and included:
  - Recording stipends
  - Jazz instructor
  - Accompanist
  - Other typical spring expenses
- Tracy noted WHIP may come close to budget by year end, depending on remaining income.
- Tracy was thanked for keeping finances on track.

### **Walnut Fest / Foundation Check Clarification**

- Discussion held about confusion around checks and donations labeled for 2024 versus 2025 Walnut Fest.
- A message from Michelle K. indicated one check may have been for a prior year or may have been mislabeled.
- Follow-up is needed to clarify whether the funds were connected to Walnut Fest, the Foundation, or a separate donation.

## **5. Fundraising / Development**

## **Patron Donor**

- Melanie was unable to attend.
- Patron donations continue to come in.
- An additional \$2,000–\$3,000 has been received recently.
- Melanie has agreed to continue the Patron Donor role next year.

## **Pampered Chef Fundraiser**

- Pampered Chef fundraiser raised approximately \$400.
- An additional approximately \$600 came in through direct patron donations connected to the fundraiser.
- Total benefit was approximately \$1,000.

## **Grants**

- Aubrey will explore grants with Nisha.
- Some grant opportunities may align with helping students who need assistance paying participation fees.
- Aubrey plans to meet with Nisha after the budget is finalized.

## **Cookie Dough Fundraiser**

- Contact has been made with the Cookie Dough representative.
- Planned start date: September 3.
- Fundraiser has been very successful in recent years.
- WHIP agreed this is worth continuing.

## **6. Outreach**

- Rishi was unable to attend.
- Rishi has received choir information.
- Band still needs to send senior names and school/next-step information.
- Directors will try to provide information by Friday.

- Rishi plans to work on the newsletter over the weekend and send it early the following week.
- Outreach/newsletter coordinator role remains open for next year.
  - Role is flexible and can be done mostly on the coordinator's own time.
  - WHIP members were asked to think of possible volunteers.

## 7. Volunteers

- Hao was unable to attend but is working with Melissa on the volunteer coordinator transition.
- Melissa will serve as volunteer coordinator next year.
- Concert SignUpGenius appears to be in decent shape.
- Leslie will serve as concert captain for the upcoming concerts.
- Leslie should count the concert captain work toward her paid hours because of the number of concerts.
- If needed, WHIP may send one more email reminder for volunteers.
- Tri-M students may also help with concerts.

## 8. Officer Elections for Next Year

### Executive Board Slate

- Proposed slate:
  - **President:** Hao Cong
  - **Vice President:** Betsy Jo Wesley
  - **Secretary:** Patricia Duque Campos
  - **Treasurer:** Tracy Cohen
- Aubrey will step down as co-president.
- Aubrey will move into Walnut Fest chair and possibly other fundraising/event roles.

- Patricia agreed to continue as secretary.
- Tracy agreed to continue as treasurer.
- Vote held on executive board slate.
- **Result:** Approved
- Person being added as authorized by the board to be a signatory on all WHIP PNC accounts is Hao Cong. Signatories to delete is Aubrey Backscheider and Betsy Jo Wesley.

## Other Roles for Next Year

- **Patron Donor:** Melanie
- **Volunteer Coordinator:** Melissa
- **Fundraising / Walnut Fest:** Aubrey
- **Outreach / Newsletter:** Open

## 9. Other Items

### Beginning-of-Year WHIP Parent Event

- Mr. Peebles suggested a large beginning-of-year WHIP/music parent gathering.
- Goal would be to help new music parents meet WHIP, directors, and other families.
- Possible ideas discussed:
  - Barbecue or smoker
  - Tie-in with back-to-school/new-family night
  - WHIP table or dedicated room
  - Food/social component to encourage connection
- WHIP noted that the general open house was not effective for outreach last year.

- Most visitors only asked for directions.
- Back-to-school/new-family night may be a better opportunity.
- Executive board will discuss before the start of school.

## Post-Meeting Gathering

- Group planned to go to Rusk after the meeting.

## 10. Action Items

- **Patricia:** Send meeting notes sooner rather than later due to technical difficulties and attendance issues.
- **Tracy / Finance:** Follow up on Walnut Fest/Foundation check confusion and clarify whether funds were for 2024 or 2025.
- **Executive Board:** Meet with Rick to review and approve the budget.
- **Aubrey:** Meet with Nisha about possible grant opportunities after the budget is finalized.
- **Band Directors:** Send senior names and school/next-step information to Rishi by Friday if possible.
- **Hao / Melissa:** Continue volunteer coordinator transition.
- **WHIP Leadership:** Continue searching for an outreach/newsletter coordinator for next year.
- **Fundraising Team:** Continue planning Cookie Dough fundraiser with September 3 start date.
- **WHIP Leadership:** Revisit beginning-of-year parent gathering idea before school starts.
- **Steel Band / WHIP:** Consider publicity and ticketing plan for March 6, 2027 steel band anniversary concert.

## 11. Adjournment

- Meeting concluded with thanks to attendees and board members.

- Meeting adjourned around 8:19 PM.